



UNITED STATES COURTS STUDY GUIDE



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1. Letter from the Secretariat

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It is my great pleasure to welcome you to the 2026 session of TEKMUN. On behalf of the Secretariat and the Organization Team, we are very excited to host you for an amazing experience of diplomacy, negotiation, and teamwork.

In today's fast-changing world, we need critical thinking and cooperation more than ever. At TEKMUN'26, we believe that young people are not just future leaders, but today's problem solvers, we aim to provide a platform where different views come together to create new solutions.

Our team has carefully prepared a wide range of committees. Whether this is your first time as a delegate or you are highly experienced, you will find a great place to express your ideas. Throughout the conference, we expect to see active debates, strong teamwork, and, above all, mutual respect. We're not preparing just any conference, we're bringing a new vision to Tekirdag's MUN Culture

I encourage you to take this opportunity with an open mind. Challenge yourselves, listen to others, and try to find a common ground. Let's work together to make TEKMUN'26 a highly successful and memorable conference.

I look forward to meeting you all very soon.

Sincerely,

Mehmet Emre Battal

2. Letter from the Committee Board

Dear Delegates,

It is our great pleasure to welcome you to the U.S. Federal Court Committee of TEKMUN'26.

As your Co-Under-Secretaries-General, we are honored to guide you through this unique and intellectually stimulating judicial committee. Unlike traditional MUN committees, the U.S. Federal Court will require you to approach the case through legal reasoning, evidence, procedure, and the principles of due process.

Throughout the committee, you will examine *United States v. Sean “Diddy” Combs*, focusing on the legal issues surrounding the case, the evaluation of evidence, and the roles of the prosecution and defense.

We encourage every delegate to approach the case with objectivity and an open mind. Distinguishing allegations from established facts and supporting your arguments with relevant legal reasoning will be essential throughout the proceedings.

We hope this committee will provide you with a challenging yet rewarding experience and help you develop your skills in argumentation, critical thinking, and public speaking.

We look forward to seeing your arguments and discussions throughout the committee.

Good luck, and see you at TEKMUN'26!

Sincerely,

Ecrin Manav & Yunus Emre Ergin
Co-Under-Secretaries-General

3. Introduction to the Committee

The US Constitution houses its own unique structure. In this unique structure, there are two main court systems: The Federal Court System and the State Court System. Each of these systems has both similarities and differences. To fully understand the US judicial structure, we should first dig into the US Court System and its procedure.

To begin with, the United States Federal Court System has three main levels: the district courts, the circuit courts and the Supreme Court. There are 94 district courts being the first level of justice. It continues with 13 circuit courts, which are above the district courts. As the final level of justice, there is one Supreme Court throughout the country. Federal courts are courts of limited jurisdiction, meaning they can only hear cases authorized by the United States Constitution or federal statutes. The federal district court is the starting point for any case arising under the Constitution. In some situations, cases that are entirely based on state law may be brought in federal court under the court's "diversity jurisdiction". Federal judges are selected by the President and confirmed "with the advice and consent" of the Senate and "shall hold their Offices during good Behavior".

In order to detail more, the district courts are the general trial courts of the federal court system. District courts handle trials within the federal court system, both civil and criminal. Some tasks of the district court are given to federal magistrate judges. Federal trial courts have also been established for a few subject-specific areas.

Once the federal district court has decided a case, the case can be appealed to a United States court of appeals. Thirteen federal circuits divide the country into different regions. Any case may be appealed to the circuit court once the district court has finalized a decision. Appeals to circuit courts are first heard by a panel, consisting of three circuit court judges.

The Supreme Court of the United States is the highest in the American judicial system and has the power to decide appeals on all cases brought in federal court or those brought in state court but dealing with federal law. Parties may file a "writ of certiorari" to the court, asking it to hear the case. Certiorari is not often granted; less than 1% of appeals to the high court are actually heard by it. There are nine justices on the court, eight associate justices and one chief justice.

State courts are courts of "general jurisdiction," which means they can hear nearly any kind of case, including the great majority of everyday civil and criminal cases, in contrast to federal courts with

limited jurisdiction. State judges are chosen by a variety of processes, including public elections or gubernatorial appointment and frequently hold office for set terms rather than "during good behavior." In contrast, federal judges are appointed for life. Starting with trial courts (commonly referred to as superior or circuit courts) and progressing to intermediate appellate courts, where panels of judges review rulings, the organization is similar to the federal system. Lastly, there is the State Supreme Court, which has the authority to select which cases it considers and acts as the final level in the state legislation and the state constitution.

The United States Criminal Court System is the primary national organ designed to enforce criminal laws, deter crime, and ensure individual accountability for offenses committed within its borders. Through the application of criminal justice, the system aims to punish wrongdoers, protect public safety, and uphold the constitutional rights of the accused. As a system fundamentally based on dual sovereignty, it operates through distinct Federal and State jurisdictions that generally complement each other rather than being in competition. The fundamental operational principles of the U.S. system are rooted in the U.S. Constitution.

The U.S. system is not governed by a single, self-executing international treaty. Instead, it is an integrated, yet decentralized, structure whose purpose is to bring charges against individuals for crimes defined by federal or state statutes. Federal Courts handle violations of U.S. Congressional laws (e.g., interstate drug trafficking), while State Courts handle the overwhelming majority of common-law crimes (e.g., murder, robbery). This structure ensures that both national and local legal concerns are addressed under their appropriate authority. The bedrock document establishing the powers and limitations of the system is the U.S. Constitution, specifically the Bill of Rights. Among other things, the Constitution sets out the fundamental rights of the accused, the rules regarding evidence admissibility (Fourth Amendment), and the right to due process (Fifth and Fourteenth Amendments). These foundational rules govern the proceedings, evidence standards, and the requirement for the prosecution to prove guilt Beyond a Reasonable Doubt to a jury of peers.

4. Background of the Case

Sean “Diddy” Combs is an American music producer, entrepreneur, and recording artist who has been a major figure in the entertainment industry for many years. In 2024, federal authorities began investigating allegations involving Combs and his activities. He was

arrested on September 16, 2024, and was subsequently charged in the United States District Court for the Southern District of New York (SDNY).

The original federal indictment included three charges: racketeering conspiracy, sex trafficking by force, fraud, or coercion, and transportation to engage in prostitution. Prosecutors alleged that Combs used his businesses, employees, financial resources, and influence to support and conceal criminal activities. These were allegations made by the prosecution, and under U.S. law, Combs was presumed innocent unless proven guilty in court.

During the trial, the prosecution presented testimony from witnesses along with documentary and other forms of evidence. The defense challenged the government's interpretation of this evidence and argued that the prosecution had failed to prove the most serious charges beyond a reasonable doubt. As a result, one of the main questions before the jury was whether the evidence was strong enough to meet the legal requirements for each individual charge.

The trial was held in federal court in 2025 and attracted significant public and media attention. Throughout the proceedings, the court was required to consider the credibility and relevance of the evidence, the interpretation of federal criminal law, the burden of proof, and the constitutional rights of the defendant. Because of this, the case also offers a useful example of how the U.S. federal justice system handles a highly publicized criminal prosecution.

On July 2, 2025, the jury reached a mixed verdict. Combs was found not guilty of racketeering conspiracy and sex trafficking, but was found guilty on two counts of transportation to engage in prostitution.

The case then moved to the sentencing stage. On October 3, 2025, Combs was sentenced to 50 months in prison for the offenses for which he was convicted.

For the TEKMUN'26 U.S. Federal Court Committee, this case provides an opportunity to examine how the American federal justice system operates in practice. Delegates should focus on issues such as the burden of proof, the admissibility and evaluation of evidence, due process, and the different roles of the prosecution and defense. It is also important to distinguish between allegations made during a trial and facts that have actually been proven in court. Rather than approaching the case based on public opinion or media coverage, delegates should evaluate the arguments and evidence using the legal standards that apply in a federal criminal proceeding.

5. Key Figures and Parties

Prosecution Party: The United States Government

The Prosecution, representing the United States Government, sought to prove that Sean “Diddy” Combs was responsible for a series of criminal activities and that his businesses, employees, and influence were used to support or conceal those activities.

The Prosecution built its case around several key arguments.

First, the government argued that Combs was involved in a criminal enterprise that operated over an extended period of time. Under the RICO statute, the Prosecution had to establish that such an enterprise existed and that Combs participated in a pattern of racketeering activity connected to it. The government presented evidence intended to show that his position and resources allowed him to organize, facilitate, or conceal criminal conduct.

Second, the Prosecution relied heavily on testimony from witnesses who described their experiences with Combs and provided information about the events examined during the trial. The government argued that this testimony, together with documentary evidence and other material presented in court, demonstrated that the alleged conduct was not made up of isolated incidents but formed part of a broader pattern.

Third, the Prosecution focused on the charges of sex trafficking and transportation to engage in prostitution. Prosecutors argued that Combs used force, fraud, or coercion in connection with the alleged sex trafficking offenses. They also argued that evidence presented at trial established the necessary elements of the transportation charges.

Ultimately, the Prosecution's responsibility was not simply to show that Combs had behaved inappropriately or that questionable events had occurred. It had to prove every element of each individual charge beyond a reasonable doubt. The government therefore presented its case as an attempt to establish criminal responsibility through the combined weight of witness testimony, documents, communications, and other

evidence.

Defendant Party: Sean “Diddy” Combs and the Defense

The Defense sought to challenge the government's interpretation of the evidence and argued that the Prosecution had failed to meet the required burden of proof.

One of the Defense's main strategies was to challenge the credibility and interpretation of witness testimony. The Defense argued that certain witnesses had complicated personal relationships with Combs and that their accounts should therefore be examined carefully. Rather than accepting every allegation as established fact, the Defense emphasized inconsistencies and alternative explanations in the testimony presented to the jury.

The Defense also challenged the government's interpretation of the evidence. According to the Defense, some of the events and communications presented by the Prosecution could be understood in different ways and did not necessarily prove that Combs had committed the specific crimes with which he was charged. This was particularly important for the more serious charges, where the government was required to prove specific legal elements such as force, fraud, or coercion.

Finally, the Defense relied on the principle of reasonable doubt. Combs was presumed innocent throughout the proceedings and was not required to prove his innocence. The Defense therefore argued that even if some of the evidence suggested inappropriate or troubling behavior, that was not enough to establish criminal guilt unless the government could prove every required element of the charges beyond a reasonable doubt.

The Defense's overall position was that the case should be decided according to the evidence and the law rather than public opinion or the extensive media attention surrounding Combs

6. Current Situation

The U.S. Federal Court Committee begins at a critical stage in the proceedings surrounding **United States v. Sean “Diddy” Combs**. While the historical trial and its verdict provide the foundation of the committee, the proceedings in TEKMUN’26 will develop through a fictional crisis scenario in which delegates will be required to respond to rapidly changing circumstances.

At the beginning of the committee, delegates will receive information regarding the current state of the case, including the available evidence, relevant witnesses, legal positions, and responsibilities of their assigned characters. From this point onward, new developments may be introduced by the Crisis Directorate.

These developments may include the emergence of new evidence, unexpected witness testimony, legal disputes, procedural complications, or information concerning individuals connected to the case. Delegates will have to assess each development carefully and determine how it affects their legal strategy.

The committee will not necessarily follow the historical events of the case. Delegates' decisions, directives, and courtroom actions will influence how the crisis develops. As a result, cooperation, strategic thinking, legal reasoning, and the ability to react to unexpected events will be essential.

Delegates should remember that every action must remain consistent with their assigned role and the authority available to them. The objective is not simply to reach a predetermined outcome, but to create a dynamic and realistic simulation of the U.S. federal judicial system.

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7. Sides of the Case

The United States Government

The United States Government represents the prosecution in the case and is responsible for presenting evidence against Sean Combs. Federal prosecutors argued that Combs had engaged in activities that violated federal law and sought to prove the charges against him beyond a reasonable doubt. To support their case, they presented witness testimony, documents, and other forms of evidence. However, the prosecution's task was not simply to show that questionable or inappropriate conduct had taken place. It had to prove that the specific legal requirements for each charge had been met.

Sean “Diddy” Combs and the Defense

Sean Combs was the defendant in the case and was represented by a team of defense attorneys. The defense challenged the government's interpretation of the evidence and argued that the prosecution had not met its burden of proof. Combs was presumed innocent throughout the trial and was not required to prove his own innocence. Instead, the defense's main goal was to raise reasonable doubt about the charges and offer different interpretations of the evidence and testimony presented by the prosecution.

Witnesses and Alleged Victims

Witnesses were an important part of the proceedings, as they provided testimony about their experiences, relationships with Combs, and other information related to the allegations. Some witnesses had personal relationships with Combs, while others provided information connected to the wider investigation. The court and jury had to consider the credibility and consistency of their statements, as well as how relevant their testimony was to the charges. Statements and allegations made by witnesses were not automatically treated as proven facts and had to be evaluated according to the rules of evidence.

The Judge and the Court

The judge was responsible for making sure that the trial followed federal law and the rules of criminal procedure. This included deciding legal questions, ruling on whether certain evidence could be presented, explaining the relevant law to the jury, and maintaining order throughout the proceedings. The judge and the court did not represent either side of the case. Their responsibility was to ensure that the trial was conducted fairly and that the rights of both the defendant and the prosecution were respected.

The Jury

The jury was responsible for reviewing the evidence presented during the trial and deciding whether the prosecution had proven each charge beyond a reasonable doubt. Jurors were expected to base their decisions on the evidence presented in court and the legal instructions given by the judge, rather than on media reports or public opinion. After considering the case, the jury returned a mixed verdict. Combs was found not guilty of racketeering conspiracy and sex trafficking, but guilty on two counts of transportation to engage in prostitution.

Federal Law Enforcement

Federal law enforcement agencies played a role in the investigation that took place before the trial. Their responsibilities included investigating the allegations and gathering evidence that could potentially be used

in a federal criminal case. Some of the evidence collected during the investigation later became part of the prosecution's case. However, an investigation or an allegation by itself does not establish criminal responsibility. The final decision on guilt was made through the federal court system, based on the evidence presented at trial and the applicable burden of proof.

8. Timeline of the Case

November 2023, Cassie Ventura (Sean Combs's ex girlfriend) sued Sean Combs of sexual assault that lasted years. This incident became the inception of federal investigation.

May 2024, CNN released a video tape of a hotel security camera showcasing Combs physically assaulting Ventura from 2016.

September 2024, Combs was arrested in Manhattan. Federal prosecutors accused him of racketeering and sex trafficking by fraud/force.

May-July 2025, At United States District Court for the Southern District of New York, a six week trial was established with the chairing of Judge Arun Subramanian.

July 2, 2025, Sean Combs was found guilty of interstate transportation for the purpose of prostitution (2 counts) under the Mann Act, however acquitted of forced sexual trafficking and racketeering by Jury.

October 3, 2025, Judge Subramanian ruled 50 months imprisonment, 500,000 dollars fine and 5 years of supervised release. Prosecution demanded over 11 years.

October 2025, Combs's advocates (with the leadership of Alexandra Shapiro) appealed to the Second Circuit Court of Appeals. Expedited review was demanded and accepted.

April 9, 2026, Oral arguments were presented before a three-judge panel (Merriam, Nardini, Baker). A decision has not yet been announced.

9.Evidence and Witnesses

Evidence and witness testimony are among the most important elements of a criminal trial. In the U.S. Federal Court Committee, delegates will be expected to examine the reliability, relevance, and significance of the evidence presented throughout the proceedings.

Evidence

The prosecution's case involved multiple forms of evidence, including witness testimony, communications, business records, photographs, videos, and other documentary materials. Such evidence was presented to establish connections between the defendant, the alleged conduct, and the charges brought against him.

However, the existence of evidence does not automatically establish guilt. Each piece of evidence must be evaluated according to its relevance, reliability, and ability to prove a particular element of a charge. The defense may challenge the interpretation, credibility, or admissibility of evidence presented by the prosecution.

Delegates should therefore consider several important questions when examining evidence:

- Is the evidence directly relevant to the charge?
- Is its source reliable?
- Can its authenticity be established?
- Does it support or contradict witness testimony?
- Does it prove an element of the offense, or merely suggest that something occurred?
- Could the evidence be interpreted in more than one reasonable way?

Witnesses

Witnesses may provide firsthand information about events, relationships, communications, or circumstances relevant to the case. Their testimony can be particularly important when documentary or physical evidence does not provide a complete picture.

The credibility of a witness can be examined through their consistency, personal knowledge, potential bias, and relationship to the parties involved. During cross-examination, attorneys may challenge inconsistencies or question the reliability of a witness's recollection.

For the purposes of the committee, new witnesses may also be introduced through crisis updates. Delegates should be prepared to assess unexpected testimony and determine how it affects their legal strategy.

Evaluating Evidence

Both the prosecution and defense must distinguish between **allegations, evidence, and established facts**. The prosecution carries the burden of proving the charges beyond a

reasonable doubt, while the defense may challenge whether the evidence is sufficient to meet that standard.

Delegates should avoid relying on media coverage or public perception when evaluating evidence. Instead, every claim should be examined through the applicable rules of evidence and principles of due process.

The Crisis Directorate may introduce additional evidence or witnesses during the committee. Delegates should carefully consider how each development affects their case and respond through appropriate courtroom actions or crisis directives.

10. Glossary of Legal Terms

Accused — A person who is alleged to have committed a crime.

Arraignment — A court proceeding in which the defendant is formally informed of the charges and enters a plea.

Beyond a Reasonable Doubt — The highest standard of proof in criminal cases. The prosecution must convince the jury that there is no reasonable doubt about the defendant's guilt.

Burden of Proof — The responsibility of proving the allegations in a criminal case. In a criminal trial, this responsibility rests with the prosecution.

Defendant — The individual formally accused of committing a crime.

Direct Evidence — Evidence that directly establishes a fact without requiring an inference, such as firsthand testimony about an event.

Due Process — The legal principle requiring that a person receive fair treatment and proper legal procedures throughout a judicial proceeding.

Evidence — Information, objects, documents, or testimony presented to establish or challenge facts in a case.

Exhibit — A document, object, recording, or other piece of evidence formally presented during a trial.

Grand Jury — A group of citizens responsible for determining whether there is sufficient evidence to formally charge someone with a federal crime.

Indictment — A formal accusation charging an individual with one or more criminal offenses.

Objection — A formal statement by an attorney challenging the admissibility or relevance of evidence, testimony, or a question.

Plea — The defendant's formal response to a criminal charge, such as guilty or not guilty.

Presumption of Innocence — The principle that a defendant is considered innocent unless the prosecution proves their guilt according to the required legal standard.

Prosecution — The legal team representing the government in a criminal case.

Reasonable Doubt — A level of uncertainty that prevents a jury from being firmly convinced of the defendant's guilt.

Relevant Evidence — Evidence that has a logical connection to an issue or fact that must be established in the case.

Testimony — A statement given by a witness under oath during a judicial proceeding.

Verdict — The formal decision reached by a jury regarding the defendant's guilt or innocence.

Witness — A person who provides information or testimony relevant to the case.

Cross-Examination — The questioning of a witness by the opposing side after the witness has given their initial testimony.

Mistrial — A trial that is terminated before a valid verdict can be reached because of a serious procedural or legal problem.

Motion — A formal request made by an attorney asking the court to make a specific ruling or take a particular action.

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